

SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW: UNIVERSITY OF ARKANSAS - MONTICELLO

TRADITIONAL AND ALTERNATIVE

On-Site Review: Date not reported

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

PERFORMANCE LEVEL	WHAT THE RATING MEANS
4 — EXCEEDS	Coursework and training CONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
3 — MEETS	Coursework and training USUALLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
2 — APPROACHING	Coursework and training INCONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
1 — BELOW	Coursework and training RARELY OR DO NOT address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.

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REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS		
REVIEW AREA 1 LITERACY COURSEWORK	REVIEW AREA 2 FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES	REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT
MEETS	MEETS	MEETS
CRITERIA REVIEWED		
9	11	7

PROGRAM INFORMATION

INSTITUTION NAME	University of Arkansas - Monticello
LOCATION	Monticello, Arkansas
PROGRAM REVIEWED	Undergraduate K-6 elementary education and the graduate Master of Arts in Teaching program, literacy
PATHWAY	Traditional and Alternative
REVIEW FRAMEWORK	TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024)
REVIEWING BODY	Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)
SITE VISIT DATES	Not reported

REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF LITERACY COURSEWORK

REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS 9 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Overview of the science of reading	Meets
Concepts of print instruction	Meets
Collaborative communication, oral language instruction	UG Meets; MAT Approaching
Phonological and phonemic awareness instruction	Exceeds
Phonics, orthography, automatic word recognition instruction	UG Meets; MAT Approaching
Fluency instruction	Meets
Vocabulary instruction	Meets
Text comprehension instruction	Meets
Writing instruction	Meets
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers examined syllabi, course materials and instructor interviews for three undergraduate literacy courses, READ 20233, READ 40133 and READ 41433, and for two MAT courses, READ 50133 and READ 50233, observing two live lessons and reviewing recordings in the online learning management system. The report rates each criterion separately for the two routes, and seven of the nine criteria carried the same rating on both. Phonological and phonemic awareness instruction exceeded expectations on both routes, supported by a phonological skills progression chart, Elkonin boxes practice and scored sample student videos. Two criteria differed. Oral language instruction met expectations on the undergraduate route, where an REL Southeast emergent literacy module supplied explicit instruction, and was approaching on the MAT route, where candidates had limited practice with oral language routines. Phonics, orthography and automatic word recognition instruction met expectations on the undergraduate route and was approaching on the MAT route, where coursework referenced blending and connected-text routines that candidates did not practice.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Increase attention to diverse learners by adding coursework, assignments, practice and field opportunities focused on neurodiversity, dialectic and linguistic diversity, and gifted and talented students, with practical strategies and strong models candidates can apply • Add field experiences across the undergraduate literacy coursework sequence so candidates observe and practice high-quality instruction before clinical placements, expanding beyond the current six hours of fieldwork limited to observation and simulated assessment, planning, instruction and intervention • Grow the master's program bank of demonstration videos, sample materials and models of high-quality literacy instruction and HQIM use so candidates have multiple and varied simulated examples in assessment and instruction regardless of their school setting	

REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS 11 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Selection of clinical placement schools	UG Meets; MAT Not rated
Selection of cooperating teachers (mentor teachers)	UG Exceeds; MAT Approaching
Opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice	UG Exceeds; MAT Meets
Field-based placements provide opportunities to use HQIM	Exceeds
Responsibilities build to candidate readiness for full responsibility	Meets
Opportunities to apply learning about multilingual children	Meets
Opportunities to apply learning about students who experience difficulty reading	Meets
Mentor teachers are skillful and can coach candidates	Exceeds
Faculty and supervisors guide and evaluate candidates through training	Meets
Quality of written and oral feedback	Meets
Student engagement and candidate impact on student learning	UG Meets; MAT Approaching
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers completed five live and seven recorded observations of candidates, interviewed university supervisors, mentor teachers and partner district leaders, and visited five clinical sites. Seven of the eleven criteria carried the same rating on both routes, including field-based placements providing opportunities to use HQIM, which exceeded expectations. Four criteria differed. Selection of clinical placement schools met expectations on the undergraduate route and was not rated on the MAT route, because districts hire residents as teachers of record. Selection of cooperating teachers exceeded expectations for interns and was approaching for residents, where the program did not consistently monitor mentor quality. Opportunities to observe models of effective practice exceeded expectations for interns and met them for residents. Student engagement and candidate impact met expectations for interns and was approaching for residents.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Improve the quality and consistency of written and oral feedback across all mentor teachers, including those supporting MAT candidates, and university supervisors through high-impact training with examples, nonexamples and models • Verify that all candidates apply their learning about diverse learners, including multilingual learners and students with disabilities, by supplying virtual, simulated, near-peer or within-school experiences when the placement classroom does not offer them • Add authentic responsibilities to pre-practicum and practicum experiences so candidates build readiness for full responsibility in the licensure role, including implementing instruction, adapting HQIM, supporting students experiencing difficulty and administering assessments	

REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS 7 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Quality of data the program collects and uses	Exceeds
Internal quality control gates (or checkpoints) and intervention plans	Meets
Quality of monitoring	Meets
Monitoring coursework quality, teaching quality, and clinical connections	Meets
Quality improvement planning	Meets
Partnerships improve candidate experiences with HQIM	Exceeds
Evaluation of partnerships for readiness to teach early literacy	UG Approaching; MAT Below
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers examined the program's data collection, monitoring routines, quality improvement planning and district partnerships. The report states a single rating covering both routes for the first six criteria and splits only the seventh. The quality of data the program collects and uses exceeded expectations, drawing on enrollment and completion data, licensure data, Praxis pass rates, employment outcomes, supervisor and completer surveys, and Aspiring Teacher Rubric analysis by cohort, although the program lacked access to pre-conference, observation and post-conference cycle data for MAT residents. Partnerships that improve candidate experiences with HQIM also exceeded expectations, supported by a survey of partner districts and grant-funded sample materials. Internal quality control gates, quality of monitoring, monitoring of coursework quality and quality improvement planning each met expectations, with reviewers describing the monitoring and improvement planning systems as informal and not well documented. Evaluation of partnerships for readiness to teach early literacy was approaching on the undergraduate route, where monitoring rested on word of mouth and candidate feedback, and below on the MAT route, where the program rarely monitored these relationships.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
- Formalize existing partnerships with measurable criteria for high-quality placement sites covering school performance and improvement, capacity and use of HQIM, and excellence in the science of reading, and monitor and evaluate district partnerships to widen candidate experiences - Formally establish and document the system for quality improvement planning, include all relevant stakeholders in ongoing and reciprocal action planning with measurable goals, and document a complete cycle of monitoring, acting on results and assessing the impact of improvement steps	

Sources: TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review, University of Arkansas – Monticello, conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024). Rating scale language quoted from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework.